

Taking on Goliath

Dinsha Patel may not have been the first choice of the Congress to take on Narendra Modi but his impeccable image and unimpeachable integrity ensure that he is the party's best bet

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Until about a week back, the mention of the name Dinsha J. Patel would have evoked the response "Dinsha who?" from all except perhaps die hard Congress workers in Gujarat and maybe his fellow ministers and parliamentarians. But he is the Union minister of state for petroleum in the UPA Government, a post in which he has largely remained under the shadow of his senior, Murli Deora. In political circles, he is also highly respected for his integrity. Last week, the 70-year-old got the opportunity to spread that image further and emerge as the hero of the secular classes when the Congress high command decided to

field him against Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi from Maninagar constituency in the Assembly election scheduled in December. Apprehensive perhaps of the David-versus-Goliath nature of the fight, Patel was, at the outset, reportedly reluctant to join, but relented only when it was made clear to him that he did not have an option. In a subsequent statement Patel said, he was "ready for the battle". "I will fight with all my strength."

Last week, as the two main parties finalised their candidates, the questions uppermost on political observers' minds were: in fielding Patel, will the Congress succeed in pinning down **MULTI-FACETED: Modi supporters at an election rally in Ahmedabad**

Modi to his own constituency and will Modi be able to overcome the wave of dissension that followed the denial of tickets to 39 MLAs and the revolt of 10 senior MLAs who are contesting as independents or as candidates of Uma Bharati's Bharatiya Jana Shakti Party?

Both sides have played their caste cards carefully. The challenge before BJP was to counter the anti-Patel image thrust upon it by the rebels led by Keshubhai Patel and Gordhan Jhadaphiya whereas for the Congress it was in catering to its original OBC vote bank and at the same time not antagonising the powerful Patels. That explains as many as 50 Patels and 40 OBCs in the BJP camp; the Congress fielded 59 OBCs and 38 Patels. However, at 24,

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